

Where Faith Meets the Earth

It gives me immense pleasure, and no small measure of pride, to write the Foreword to *Eco-Spirituality and World Religions* by Dr. Devinder Pal Singh. I have known Devinder for several decades now, first as a keen young student with a scientist's curiosity and a seeker's heart, and later as a valued colleague and friend. To watch that early curiosity mature into a body of scholarship that bridges physics, philosophy, and faith has been one of the genuine satisfactions of my own academic life. This book is, in many ways, the natural culmination of a journey he has been on for years: the search for where hard science and living faith meet, and what they might say to each other about the crisis now facing our planet.

We live at a strange moment in human history. Never has our species possessed more precise knowledge of the natural world, and never has that knowledge translated so poorly into right action. We can model the melting of glaciers, chart the rise of the oceans, and count the species we are losing with mathematical precision, and yet the will to change course remains stubbornly elusive. Dr. Singh's central insight in this volume is one I have long shared: that the missing ingredient is not more data but a different relationship with the Earth itself, one in which nature is regarded not merely as a resource to be managed but as sacred ground to be revered. This is the terrain of eco-spirituality, and it is here that the world's religious traditions, so often dismissed by the modern mind as relics of a pre-scientific age, turn out to hold some of our oldest and wisest counsel.

The structure of this book reflects the rigour and breadth that have always marked Dr. Singh's writing. He begins, sensibly, by laying the groundwork: what we mean by religion in a plural and often fractured modern world, what spirituality is and is not, and what ecology teaches us about sustainability as a discipline in its own right. Only after this careful scaffolding does he turn to the heart of the book, a sweeping survey of eco-spiritual thought across the great religious traditions of humankind.

Christianity's theology of stewardship, Islam's concept of mizan or balance, Hinduism's reverence for the sacred rivers and forests, Buddhism's teaching of interdependence, and the Sikh vision of the Divine pervading all creation, are each given their due, alongside the ecological wisdom of Jain ahimsa, Judaism's covenantal care for creation, Shinto's ritual sense of nature's sanctity, the ancient harmonies of Chinese folk religion and Taoism, the Bahá'í vision of unity, and the Quaker testimony of simplicity. I found particular resonance, as a Sikh, in the chapter on the Guru Granth Sahib's spiritual ecology; but I would urge every reader, whatever their own tradition or none, to read each chapter with equal attention, for the deeper argument of this book is that these are not competing accounts but complementary facets of a single human recognition: that we belong to the Earth, not the other way around.

The second part of the book, profiling the eminent men and women who have given eco-spirituality its modern voice, is equally valuable. Devinder brings together an unusually wide-ranging company: the theologian Thomas Berry alongside the Kenyan environmentalist Wangari Maathai; the philosopher Arne Naess, father of deep ecology, alongside the Buddhist teacher Thich Nhat Hanh and the Vedantic sage Ramana Maharshi; Guru Nanak and Guru Har Rai alongside Pope Francis and Seyyed Hossein Nasr; John Muir and Vandana Shiva alongside Satish Kumar and Joanna Macy. It is a rare gift to place such figures side by side without flattening their differences, and Dr. Singh manages this with the same even-handedness and clarity that has characterized his earlier books on science and Sikh thought. Readers will understand that the ecological awakening of our age has been carried forward not by any single culture or creed, but by a chorus of voices speaking, each in its own idiom, the same essential truth.

I have had the privilege of mentoring many students in Physics research over a long teaching career spanning nearly 40 years, but none has combined, as Devinder has, a physicist's discipline with a genuine reverence for the spiritual dimension of life. This book asks nothing less of its reader than a change of heart: a willingness to see the forest, the river, and the mountain not as inert matter but as bearers of meaning, worthy of the same

moral regard we extend to one another. In an age of ecological anxiety, that is not a small thing to ask, nor an easy one to grant. I believe earnestly that this book will cater to the needs of present and future generations looking for solutions to ecological disaster waiting to happen on our Earth.

I commend, “Eco-Spirituality and World Religions” to students of comparative religion, to environmentalists in search of deeper motivation, and to the general reader who simply wishes to understand why so many of humanity's oldest traditions insist that caring for the Earth is, finally, a form of prayer. I congratulate Dr. Devinder Pal Singh on a timely and important contribution, and I have no doubt it will find the wide and thoughtful readership it deserves.

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